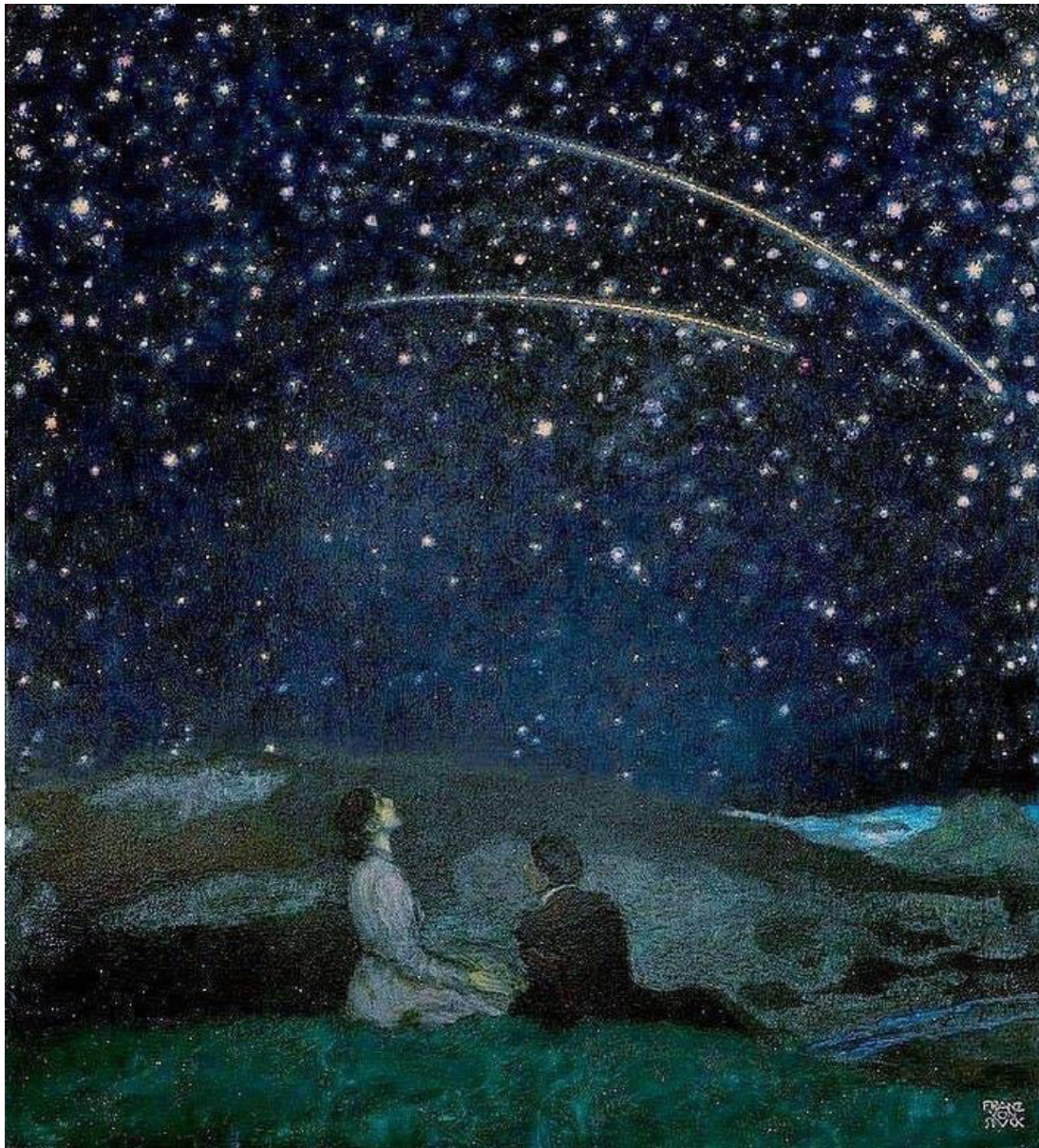


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 5

Painting the Stars ~ An Anticipatory Universe

4 October 2026



Shooting Stars | Franz von Stuck, 1912

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time.

Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on AUSTRIAN HYMN and TALLIS' CANON

ADORO TE DEVOTE

- Original Chant
- Setting by Janis Dunson Wilson
- Improvisation

Chorale Prelude on Orlando Gibbons' SONG 46 "Peace, Perfect Peace" (Anthony Giamanco)

Bicinium on CHRISTE SANCTORUM (John Barr) and Improvisation
Pastorale (Cécile Chaminade)

ST. DENIO (William H. Bates) and Improvisation

VATER UNSER IM HIMMELREICH (Samuel Scheidt)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Brittany & Lance Skiles

Since time immemorial,
we have gazed into the face of the universe,
its blind stare spilling back at us
from billions of suns, moons, and stars.

*Enriched by its mystery,
we cast into it our own –
stories of possibility, of hope, of promise.*

As we have woven our days,
pulling and stretching
to match the sacred stories we have drawn,
too often the beauty of the story
has risen far above
the realities with which we live.

*Beginning today...
may we find new stories in the skies.
Beginning today...
may we sense new stories in our hearts.*

*Beginning today...
may we write new stories on the stones of our world.*

And as we do so,
may we pour the life-changing beauty of truth
into ourselves and the world around us -
so that those who come after us might find it there,
and live strong and powerfully
in its light.

Together, we rise as those who seek to light truth's shining torch.
[rexhunt/adptlvf]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Creator of All Time and Space

TALLIS' CANNON

Creator of all time and space,
We read your image on each face.
Great Spirit of the cosmic whole,
You made us body, mind, and soul.

We thank you for the human mind,
In mystic harmony designed,
For word and image, dream and thought,
For lessons learned and answers sought.

O God of planet, moon, and sun,
We wonder, knowing all you've done,
That you befriend the human race,
And fill our lives with love and grace.

For miracles as large as space,
As small as cells, as deep as grace,
We offer you our thanks and praise,
And pledge to serve you all our days.

-lyrics by Ruth C. Duck

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

O Holy One,
by your grace
we enter now
the sacred realm,
a place of deep connection with you,
with each other,
with the planet,
and with all creation.

*By your grace,
the walls that isolate fall;
fear dissolves into trust;*

*arrogance is gentled by compassion; our need to
prove ourselves is tempered by self-acceptance.*

Now, we rest in a love
that helps us see our lives
as part of a great unity,
a coherence of grace.

*We join with all creation in
proclaiming your glory,
and the glory of being alive.*

*We pray this as people
searching for a new way.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

We Are
Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

WORDS AND MUSIC: DR. YSAYE BARNWELL

***The Lord's Prayer**

Brittany Skiles

*Great Spirit, our Creator, who is in all places,
Sacred is your name.
May your wisdom guide us,
Your will be done in our lives, as it is throughout Creation.*

*Provide for us today the nourishment we need,
And forgive us our wrongs, as we forgive those who have wronged us.*

*Lead us on the path of understanding and respect,
And protect us from ignorance and harm.*

*For you are the source of all power, beauty, and love,
From generation to generation, forever and always. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

For the sacred earth
its scents and sounds and sights
we give you thanks, O God.

For the holy heavens
their heights and depths and breadth
we give you thanks.

May we love the earth
and cherish her fecundity.
May we love the rivers
and obey their ancient purity.
*May we love the skies
and honor their infinity
all for one another.*

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Traditions

Brittany & Lance Skiles

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

We gather, reflect and share,
aware that in doing so
we give human expression
here on earth
to the Divine Mystery
present and active
everywhere in this vast universe.

We gather, reflect and share,
seeking to be enlightened
by the power and presence
of this Mystery,
here,
now,
in us,
in human form.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal One,
we have gathered to renew our confidence
in a more illumined future,
as we enter your kingdom,
here and now
as a foretaste of all that will be.

We long to give ourselves to this emerging future,
knowing that all our choices,
no matter how small,
resonate across every strand of this cosmic web.

We know, O God, that we are not alone
as people who are longing for a future that is secure.
It is our fear that keeps us looking
back over our shoulder,
and yet the Spirit is with us.
Let us not forget that are you with us -
in our passion to create this future,
and in our resolve to overcome all that keeps us
from your dream for all creation.

*Lift us up, abiding Spirit,
above all obstacles,
and grant us a glimpse
of what is possible
when hearts and minds
discover that you are in our fears,
our hopes, and our commitments.* [bsanguin/adaptlvf]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

Fly Free by Day, Swim Deep at Night
Frank Hobbs, Fahad Siadat, *Duet*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Siadat, *Conductor* DAVID MONTOYA
TEXT: WILLIAM WALLIS

Sermon

We are Stories & Stardust

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Brittany Skiles

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Star Readers

TEXT AND MUSIC: TANNER PFEIFFER

Tanner Pfeiffer, *Conductor*

*A star-filled sky once whispered of great mystery, and upturned eyes there sought a light divine.
Now smoky scars obscure the cost of certainty. To right past wrongs, our inner light we realign.*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Lance Skiles

Holy One,
We give thanks for the mystery of the universe,
for the marvel of the solar system
for the extraordinary beauty of a planet
that collectively have brought us into life
and into human awareness
of the profound interdependence of all things.

*We accept our responsibility
to do all we can
to protect,
to foster,
to defend
this exquisite and fragile web of interconnectedness.*

May we allow the Mystery
that powers and sustains the universe -
to power and sustain
our efforts
to care for
and to be worthy stewards of
this wonderful planet
on which we depend for life, health, and well-being.

*To this we give our all.
Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

May the deep blessings of earth be with us.
May the fathomless surroundings of seas surge in our soul.
May boundless stretches of the universe echo in our depths
and open us to wonder
to strengthen us for love
to humble us with gratitude
that we may find ourselves in one another
that we may lose ourselves in gladness
that we may give ourselves in peace.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

How Brightly Shines the Morning Star

PHILIPP NICOLAI

***Hymn for the Journey**

For the Music of Creation

AUSTRIAN HYMN

For the music of creation,
For the song your Spirit sings,
For your sound's divine expression,
Burst of joy in living things:
God, our God, the world's composer,
Hear us, echoes of your voice:
Music is your art, your glory,
Let the human heart rejoice!

All the voices of the ages
In transcendent chorus meet,
Worship lifting up the senses,
Hands that praise and dancing feet;
Over discord and division
Music speaks your joy and peace,
Harmony of earth and of heaven,
Song of God that cannot cease.

--lyrics by S.E. Murray

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Short Fugue in D minor (Ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Inside The Music

*"We are Stories and Stardust. I have long appreciated storytelling culture: the idea that stories are passed between generations and that we, ourselves, add breath, breadth, and depth to those stories while they journey to, through, and past us. I could think of no better invitation to our time together today than Dr. Ysaye Barnwell's poem *We Are*, serving as an evocative reminder into this wisdom. She writes, "For each child that's born a morning star rises and sings to the universe who we are. We are our grandmothers' prayers. We are our grandfathers' dreamings. We are the breath of our ancestors. We are the spirit of God. We're seekers of truth and keepers of faith, we are makers of peace and the wisdom of ages."*

In meditation, we sing David Montoya's setting of the William Wallis poem *Fly free by day, swim deep at night*, wherein two tenors duet as father and son and their shifting relationship as the son ventures on his own into adulthood. Today, our father and son are depicted by Fahad and Frank, both of whom are new dads themselves, navigating shifting waters of stories and stardust. In the piece, the choir serves as emotional support with tonal colors borrowed from the South Asian musical tradition *sargam*. It is not until the word "*peace*" that we hear a third in the chord, signifying a settled Major tonality. The material in the choir is somewhat improvisatory in nature, illustrating the freedom, and sometimes the unsettledness, of finding our way.

A feeling of improvisation and freedom also defines our offertory anthem, *Star Readers*, composed by Laude baritone Tanner Pfeiffer. In their program note, Tanner writes, "*Throughout history and across the world, cultures have looked to the stars for inspiration, beauty, prophecy, and information. As industrialization and pollution have marred the planet and hidden the stars from so many eyes, how have we been separated from the awe of our ancestors? To have a hope of repairing this human bond with the cosmos, we must join together and make a concerted effort.*" In music that illustrates this idea through an open invitation to connect with our own ancestral breath, Tanner facilitates this connection to our stories and to our formation from stardust. And finally in choral response, we sing the popular hymn tune by 16th century hymnist

Philipp Nicolai, *how brightly shines the morning star, with mercy beaming from afar: O hear our supplication.*"
~ Dr. Ianthe Marini

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